

CEM: arguments for and against

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1. For CEM for counterfactuals: from chance

How likely was it that Coin X would land Heads if it was tossed?

2. For CEM in general: from credence

How confident are you that Coin X would have landed Heads if it had been tossed?

How confident are you that Coin X landed Heads if it was tossed?

3. A response from Bennett

Admittedly, we often find it natural to say things like 'There's only a small chance that if he had entered the lottery he would have won', and 'It's 50% likely that if he had tossed the coin it would have come down heads'. In remarks like these, the speaker means something of the form $A > (P(C) = n)$ —if the antecedent were true, the consequent would have a certain probability; yet the sentence he utters means something of the form $P(A > C) = n$. According to me, these have different meanings. When we use one to mean the other we employ a usage that is idiomatic but not strictly correct. (p. 251)

Do we really conflate the things Bennett says we conflate? We'd have to conflate (1) (which looks plausibly true) with (2) (which looks clearly false)!

- (1) It is pretty likely right now that if Jim drank arsenic tomorrow, he would be dead by the weekend.
- (2) If Jim drank arsenic tomorrow, it would be pretty likely right now that he would be dead by the weekend.

4. For CEM: from our carelessness about scope

Williams: to *express our disagreement* with 'If A, it would be that B', we just say 'If A, it wouldn't be that B'.

- By contrast, if we just want to express our disagreement with 'You must not do X' we do *not* feel we have to say 'You must do X'; we just say 'You may do X'.
- Consider negative answers to yes-no questions, e.g. 'Would this coin have landed Heads if it had been tossed? — No.'
 - Claim (is this right?): saying 'no' here is inappropriate unless you have the kind of evidence that would justify saying 'It would have landed Tails if had been

tossed'. 'No, since it's perfectly fair' is weird, but on the CEM-denying view, it looks like it should be great.

Stalnaker's contrast:

- (3) a. He doesn't have to appoint any particular woman; he just has to appoint some woman or other.
- b. He won't appoint any particular woman; he just will appoint some woman or other.
- c. He wouldn't have appointed any particular woman; he just would have appointed some woman or other.

(3a) seems fine. (3b) seems weird. Stalnaker's claim: (3c) is as bad as (3b); but if CEM fails in this case, (3c) should be as good as (3a).

- Finds all these sentences to be unduly 'sloppy' as they stand, Bennett suggests fixing them up as follows.
- (4) a. There is no woman of whom it is true that he has to appoint her; he just has to appoint some woman or other.
- b. There is no woman of whom it is true that he will appoint her; he just will appoint some woman or other.
- c. There is no woman of whom it is true that he would appoint her; he just would have appointed some woman or other.
- Leave aside for now the *ad hominem* point against Stalnaker (who was led to assert (4c) by his theory of vagueness). Is the fixed-up argument actually any worse than the original?

5. For CEM: from quantified conditionals

Von Fintel and Iatridou (2002): the following seem equivalent

- (5) a. Every student will fail if he goofs off [failed if he goofed off/would fail if he goofed off]
- b. No student will pass if he goofs off [passed if he goofed off/would pass if he goofed off]

But assuming these have the logical forms they seem to have, (5b) does not entail (5a) in a logic without CEM. (What if some of the students are such that it's not the case that they will pass if they goof off, and also not the case that they will fail if they goof off?)

6. A possible response from von Fintel: CEM as a mere presupposition

Von Fintel's suggestion: 'If A, B' *presupposes* 'Either if A, B or if A, not-B'.

Combine this with a general claim about presupposition projection: if 'x is F' presupposes 'x is G', 'Every H is F' and 'No H is F' both presuppose 'Every H is G'.

Result: both (5a) and (5b) presuppose 'Every student either will fail if he goofs off, or will pass if he goofs off'.

So: (5b) is true *and its presupposition is satisfied*, (5a) is true. (And vice versa.)

This proposal also gives a response to some of the arguments about scope. But it doesn't seem to the arguments about chance and credence.